

Psalms 139

Search Me, O God

Search me, O God, and know my heart: try me, and know my thoughts
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O LORD, thou hast searched me, and known me.
- 2 Thou knowest my downsitting and mine uprising, thou understandest my thought afar off.
- 3 Thou compassest my path and my lying down, and art acquainted with all my ways.
- 4 For there is not a word in my tongue, but, lo, O LORD, thou knowest it altogether.
- 5 Thou hast beset me behind and before, and laid thine hand upon me.
- 6 Such knowledge is too wonderful for me; it is high, I cannot attain unto it.
- 7 Whither shall I go from thy spirit? or whither shall I flee from thy presence?
- 8 If I ascend up into heaven, thou art there: if I make my bed in hell, behold, thou art there.
- 9 If I take the wings of the morning, and dwell in the uttermost parts of the sea;
- 10 Even there shall thy hand lead me, and thy right hand shall hold me.
- 11 If I say, Surely the darkness shall cover me; even the night shall be light about me.
- 12 Yea, the darkness hideth not from thee; but the night shineth as the day: the darkness and the light are both alike to thee.
- 13 For thou hast possessed my reins: thou hast covered me in my mother's womb.
- 14 I will praise thee; for I am fearfully and wonderfully made: marvellous are thy works; and that my soul knoweth right well.
- 15 My substance was not hid from thee, when I was made in secret, and curiously wrought in the lowest parts of the earth.
- 16 Thine eyes did see my substance, yet being imperfect; and in thy book all my members were written, which in continuance were fashioned, when as yet there was none of them.
- 17 How precious also are thy thoughts unto me, O God! how great is the sum of them!
- 18 If I should count them, they are more in number than the sand: when I awake, I am still with thee.
- 19 Surely thou wilt slay the wicked, O God: depart from me therefore, ye bloody men.
- 20 For they speak against thee wickedly, and thine enemies take thy name in vain.
- 21 Do not I hate them, O LORD, that hate thee? and am not I grieved with those that rise up against thee?
- 22 I hate them with perfect hatred: I count them mine enemies.
- 23 Search me, O God, and know my heart: try me, and know my thoughts:
- 24 And see if there be any wicked way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 139 is among the most intimate psalms in the Psalter, tracing God's exhaustive knowledge of the psalmist across every dimension: thought, location, formation in the womb, and even the direction of his heart toward enemies of God. David moves from wonder at being fully known, through the impossibility of escaping God's presence, to worship at his own intricate creation, and finally to a request for that same searching knowledge to be turned actively on his own heart. Henry treats the psalm's arc—from being known, to inviting more scrutiny—as the mark of genuine rather than merely theoretical faith.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-6

God's knowledge is described as total and immediate: He knows the psalmist's sitting and rising, understands his thoughts from far off, is acquainted with his ways before he acts, and knows every word before it is spoken. This knowledge is called too wonderful to fully grasp—overwhelming rather than merely comforting.

Verse 7-12

The psalmist tests the limits of that presence: where could he flee to escape it—up to heaven, down to the depths, to the far side of the sea, or into darkness itself? Every possibility fails; even darkness is no hiding place, since darkness and light are both alike to God.

Verse 13-16

Attention turns to the psalmist's own formation: God covered him in the womb, wove him together there, made him fearfully and wonderfully in a way that provokes praise rather than mere biological curiosity. His days were written in God's book and fashioned before a single one of them existed—identity and lifespan both known in advance.

Verse 17-18

A brief pause for wonder: God's thoughts toward the psalmist are called precious, too many to number, more numerous than grains of sand—and remarkably, God's presence remains constant even as the psalmist wakes each new day.

Verse 19-22

The tone shifts sharply toward those who oppose God: David asks that the wicked and bloodthirsty be dealt with, declares that he hates those who hate God and counts God's enemies his own, expressing what he calls a perfect hatred. This zeal is best read as loyalty to God's honor rather than personal grudge, and stands in the same breath as the psalm's intimate self-examination, not as its final word.

Verse 23-24

The psalm's closing request turns the whole preceding meditation into a deliberate invitation: search me, God, know my heart, try me, know my thoughts, see if there is any wicked way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting. Having marveled at being fully known already, David actively invites more scrutiny rather than shrinking from it.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Being completely known by God—thoughts, location, formation, and future—is presented not as a threat to privacy but as grounds for wonder and, ultimately, an active invitation for deeper examination. Genuine faith, this psalm suggests, moves beyond simply accepting that God knows everything to actually requesting that He search, test, and correct what He finds.

Application for life today.

Let the psalm's wonder at total divine knowledge (vv. 1–6) counter any instinct to hide parts of your life from God rather than bring them into the light. Where verses 7–12 describe the impossibility of escaping God's presence, consider whether you are currently trying to outrun Him in some area, and what it would mean to stop. Make verses 23–24 an actual, specific prayer this week—naming a particular area where you genuinely want God to search and correct you, not merely affirm you.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What part of your life are you tempted to keep from God's attention, and how does this psalm's picture of total knowledge (vv. 1–6) challenge that instinct?

2. Where might you currently be trying to 'flee' from God's presence (vv. 7–12), whether through busyness, distraction, or avoidance?

3. What specific area of your heart or thoughts do you need to actually invite God to search, as David does in verses 23–24, rather than leaving unexamined?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).